

St. Joseph the All Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 4, Oct 19/Nov 1 2020

Table of Contents

Contact Info	1
Catechetical Letter 1. First things: God - He Who is; The Trinity	1
Orthodox Parables and Stories: "Thanks to St. Seraphim of Sarov no more swearing."	4
Prison ministry news	4
A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life	5
I could have known a Saint!	5
A Word from Fr. Seraphim	5
Non-negotiables.	5
A word from Fr David	6
Salvation in an Age of Politics and Protests	7
Gleanings from the Fathers: Humility	8

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Note: With God helping us we will send many newsletters to all of those that we minister to in prison. Our aim is to send a newsletter in the first and the 15th of each month. This is the 3rd, sent to 67 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at:

<http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you have a need along these lines.

Catechetical Letter 1. First things: God - He Who is; The Trinity

It is appropriate to start at the beginning when explaining something. When explaining things about God, it is more appropriate to start before the beginning. Before all things, there was God. This is the fundamental dogma of Christianity.

When asked for His name by Moses, God answered: "I AM".

"And Moses said to God, Behold, I shall go forth to the children of Israel, and shall say to them, The God of our fathers has sent me to you; and they will ask me, **What is his name?** What shall I say to them? (14) And God spoke to Moses, saying, **I am THE BEING**; and he said, Thus shall ye say to the children of Israel, THE BEING has sent me to you." (Exodus 3:13-14)

He called himself "the being", or the "existing one". Other translations say "I am whom I am". This means that only God exists in and of Himself, with no source or creator. He IS, and because He IS - all other things - stars, planets, angels, animals and men - have their existence because of Him. God is the fundamental "fact" of the universe. All things were created by Him out of nothing.

This is a well-known belief (dogma), but few understand its implications. *All dogmas have moral implications*; If we believe in a dogma, this belief must affect the way in which we live. If all things were created by God according to His sovereign and unassailable will, there is no reason for pride, or covetousness or pursuance of possessions, fame or any earthly thing, and all things find their life, and purpose and rest in God only.

Orthodox Christianity is the constant living in accordance with this conviction. In a true Christian, this conviction affects EVERY aspect of his life. All intelligent beings (men and angels) are naturally inclined to seek God, to know Him and be united with Him (according to the limits of their nature, only man can be fully united with God, since he was made to know things "the angels desire to look into"¹). This is a fundamental fact of human nature.

There is no knowledge outside of God. There is no beauty outside of God. There is no perfection outside of God. There is no life outside of God.

These are stupendous statements, that the world does not believe. We live in an age where people derive meaning for their life from things other than God. They define themselves by their talents, or desires, or possessions. There is no meaning in life apart from God, because apart from God, there is no life. All that we do that is not like God leads to death.

Orthodox Christianity may be described as an attempt to know God and be united to Him, without confusion, or shame. God progressively reveals Himself to man, who understands God's self-revelation only when his soul is in a state that *is able* to understand. Of course, all this is accomplished by grace (a word which we will define in time - the standard Western definition "unwarranted favor" is a shallow representation of this truth), and also by our desire and effort.

Let us start then, in trying to understand God. The first dogma we must understand about knowing God is that *He is transcendentally above and invisible to all His creation, except when He wills to make Himself known. Christianity is completely a revealed religion. It is the process of God revealing Himself to the human heart. Only God can give us knowledge about Himself.*

There is an important moral application to this dogma, as there always are with all dogmas. We cannot know God by our intellect, because He is above all things and invisible (completely unknown and unexperienced) to all beings except when He wills to be visible.

Our entire temporal human existence is an attempt, aided by grace, to open our hearts to the knowledge of God by changing our character to be like God. Those who do not understand this task belittle it as works-based religion or something of the like, but our entire purpose is to know God, and we can know Him only by having our hearts in a condition to understand Him as He reveals Himself to us, according to His providence and timing. This dogma is the entire reason for Christian asceticism, which we will write about in another letter.

Knowledge of God is the only important knowledge in the universe. Life lived without the goal of knowing God fully is life wasted. This may seem harsh to many who do not believe in God, or have a smaller understanding of God, but this statement is true. If God created all things, then not knowing God is the greatest tragedy for man because we were created to know God. Every action, thought, disposition and attitude in our life must be evaluated in this context.

Let us say in a simple way who God is, as He has revealed Himself to us. God has told us very little about Himself, because we are capable of understanding very little. Everything we can say about Him is because of His revelation of Himself to us, and whatever we say about Him cannot describe Him, because he is unknowable. He can only be known by experience, which He initiates. Orthodox Christianity is the practice of continually and increasingly experiencing God.

He has revealed to us that He is one God, and a Trinity of persons (or hypostases). We have little time to explain the complexity of the word "hypostases". Ultimately, the only way to understand it is for God to reveal Himself to us, and for us to know Him by experience. The whole purpose of these letters is to equip those who read them to desire to attain to the knowledge of God, and order their lives exclusively towards this end. If anyone does this, they will attain to the knowledge of God and union with Him.

The Father is the sole source of The Son and the Holy Spirit. The Son and Holy Spirit are equally eternal, and equally God as much as the Father is God. We dogmatize that Jesus, the second person of the Trinity, is eternally begotten of the Father, and that the Holy Spirit proceeds eternally from the Father. We cannot fully understand these statements, because God cannot be understood. He can be experienced, and our experience of Him brings us knowledge of Him, as He reveals Himself.

Our fundamental statement of faith states these truths about God. This statement is called the "**Nicene creed**", or the "Nicene-Constantinopolitan Creed", or in church writings, often by its first two words: "I believe". Other letters will explain this creed and do a line by line exegesis, but we will say a few things here. It was written by the entire Church, as represented by her bishops, at the first two (of 7 total) Ecumenical Councils, in the fourth century. We use this creed as a prayer in many services, such as during Morning Prayers, the Divine Liturgy, Compline, and the baptism service. We hold all words in it to be absolutely true, and absolutely necessary to believe and live by.

Here is the beginning of the Creed: "I believe in **one God, the Father Almighty**, Maker of heaven and earth, and of all things visible and invisible. And in **one Lord Jesus Christ, the Son of God, the Only-begotten, begotten of the Father before all ages. Light of Light; true God of true God, begotten, not made; of one essence with the Father by Whom all things were made;**"

Later in the Creed, the Holy Spirit is mentioned: "**And in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the Giver of Life; Who proceedeth from the Father; Who with the Father and the Son together is worshipped and glorified; Who spake by the prophets.**"

These words summarize all we know in words about the Holy Trinity. The true meaning of these words is actualized in a person only by experience.

The fact of the Holy Trinity raises an important set of questions. One can say without exaggeration that the Church's sole purpose is to answer these questions and direct its children to live according to the "One Who Is".

1. Why is believing in the Holy Trinity important? In other words, it is obligatory to believe that God is "Father, Son and Holy Spirit", or can one just as well believe in God as one person (as the Muslims do), or believe in many gods, or forms of God in nature, etc.?

2. How does the nature of the Holy Trinity affect how we should live, and determine what is "good" and "bad"?

3. How do we learn of the Holy Trinity?

4. Can we be united to the Holy Trinity, even though God is impassible, and totally transcendent and unknowable?

We will examine these questions in forthcoming letters. All further letters will have the sole intent of making us know the Holy Trinity and be united with Him.

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In Russian (in an earlier version) at: http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechetical-letter-01_2015+first-things+god-he-who-is-the-trinity-rus.doc

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<http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/to-pray-for-someone-more-diligently+prayer-of-saint-silouan.doc>

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<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/prayer-for-all-peoples-of-the-world-according-to-the-model-of-the-prayer-of-saint-silouan-of-mount-athos.doc>

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We conclude our letter with an inspired prayer of St Silouan of Mount Athos, which is good to use any time when praying for others and represents the most important things we can desire for anyone and the ***highest achievement man can attain***:

I pray Thee, O merciful Lord, for all the peoples of the world, that they may come to know Thee by the Holy Spirit.

Priest Seraphim Holland 2015-2020 seraphim@orthodox.net

[St Nicholas Orthodox Church, McKinney, Texas](#) (orthodox.net)

Bibliography of Scripture and Church hymns which illuminate the doctrine of the Holy Trinity, which can only be understood fully by experience. This list is not remotely comprehensive.

"And Moses said to God, Behold, I shall go forth to the children of Israel, and shall say to them, The God of our fathers has sent me to you; and they will ask me, **What is his name?** What shall I say to them? (14) And God spoke to Moses, saying, **I am THE BEING**; and he said, Thus shall ye say to the children of Israel, THE BEING has sent me to you." (Exodus 3:13-14)

In the beginning **God** created the heaven and the earth. (2) And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness *was* upon the face of the deep. And the **Spirit** of God moved upon the face of the waters. (3) And **God said**, Let there be light: and there was light. Genesis 1:1-3

Here the Trinity is referred to with "God" being the Father, Spirit being mentioned, and the Word (another name for Jesus, the Son of God) being mentioned by "God said".

"Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit: (20) Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, *even* unto the end of the world. Amen." Matthew 28:19-20

"And Jesus, when he was baptized, went up straightway out of the water: and, lo, the heavens were opened unto him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him: (17)

And lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased." Matthew 3:16-17

"The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ, and the love of God, and the communion of the Holy Ghost, *be* with you all. Amen." 2 Corinthians 13:14

This is a model for many of our prayers in church. Almost all "exclamations" (the ending of prayers) by the priest are a doxology (hymn of praise) to the Holy Trinity, which is explicitly mentioned.

"*There is one body, and one Spirit, even as ye are called in one hope of your calling; (5) One Lord, one faith, one baptism, (6) One God and Father of all, who is above all, and through all, and in you all.*" Ephesians 4:4-6

"Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, (2) Elect according to the foreknowledge of God the Father, through sanctification of the Spirit, unto obedience and sprinkling of the blood of Jesus Christ: Grace unto you, and peace, be multiplied." 1Peter 1:1-2

"But after that the kindness and love of God our Saviour toward man appeared, (5) Not by works of righteousness which we have done, but according to his mercy he saved us, by the washing of

regeneration, and renewing of the Holy Ghost; (6) Which he shed on us abundantly through Jesus Christ our Saviour; (7) That being justified by his grace, we should be made heirs according to the hope of eternal life." Titus 3:4-7

Orthodox Parables and Stories: "Thanks to St. Seraphim of Sarov no more swearing."

My friend Aleksey was previously known as an inspired and incorrigible swearing man. He swore with pleasure. Or rather, he did not swear, but one might say he spoke.

More than once he caused conflict situations, bringing to white heat those to whom profanity is worse than any cacophony. And he stubbornly did not recognize any prohibitions and restrictions.

We hadn't seen each other for more than six months, and when we finally met recently, I really didn't recognize my friend. In his vocabulary all obscene words have completely disappeared. Marveling at the incredible change that happened to Aleksey, I, of course, asked him: "What happened to you ?!" In response, he told me an amazing story that happened to him:

From a young age, I thought lightly that the concept "profanity is bad" ate is bad just a stupid convention, generated by man. Neither my parents, nor my acquaintances could convince me. "Well, judge for yourself," I argued my "rightness" to my opponents. Look, in Sweden, for example, swear words like ours are used everywhere, and the most indecent and offensive is the seemingly harmless one: "go to the forest!". And all because in ancient times those who were strongly guilty from the tribe were driven out into the forests, and this meant certain death. People love to invent for themselves prohibitions, so it is more interesting for them to live! And I don't give a damn about conventions!

A miracle happened last summer. I already considered myself an Orthodox believer, but I continued to use "filthy" words in my everyday life, still unwilling to admit the inadmissibility of their use. And then one day, my bride and I went on a pilgrimage trip to Diveyevo. This truly holy place near Arzamas has long attracted both pilgrims and ordinary tourists. Numerous holy springs, bathing in which one can heal even the most serious illnesses, cleanse, "rinse out" the soul; picturesque hilly meadows and forest groves. The relics of St. Seraphim of Sarov, the great prayer book of the Russian land, rest in the Diveyevo Monastery. Venerating the relics, many believers spiritually receive their sight, receive consolation and protection from diseases, "corruption". I myself saw how the demoniac was brought to the relics. With a seemingly normal woman, as soon as she entered the temple, a metamorphosis occurred. The closer she was brought to the relics,

the stronger she was, two hefty men could hardly hold her, and she made a terrible animal roar. And after that, she again became an ordinary woman, no different from the others.

The stay at the holy place bore fruit in the very first days. Swearing fell from my lips less and less, but I still "resisted". And suddenly, after another bathing in the holy spring and visiting the relics, the thought struck me like a shock: by swearing we destroy our soul, we clog it with negative energy! There was a feeling that Saint Seraphim himself led me to a simple and natural explanation of the unacceptability of obscene words.

And what is surprising - the desire to swear was cut off! The next day, walking down the street, I suddenly twisted my leg, hitting the hole. Usually, in such situations, I automatically would curse. A little later, a passing car splashed mud at me. I looked after it and had already opened my mouth to speak out a curse word, when suddenly a pleasant wave of calm extinguished, like water, the flaring fire of anger. I waved my hand and calmly walked on. The bride was shocked.

And even when we were leaving, and 5 minutes before the departure of the train, it turned out that it was leaving from another station in the opposite part of the city (thanks to the good railroad workers who were making such a mess!) We were late for the train, and had to go back two hours later in a shared carriage. I did not swear and have not sworn in the future thanks to St. Seraphim of Sarov.

Roman Pankov

<https://orthodoxgladness.blogspot.com/2020/10/orthodox-parables-and-stories-thanks-to.html>



Prison ministry news

In this newsletter it is a bit of a struggle to give you much interesting news. It might not be "news", but it is critically important that you know that Fr. David and I pray for all of

you every day. We are still working figuring out what to do to start a parole house in Marshall. We have set a goal of getting an 8-page newsletter out twice a month. This is the fourth

newsletter, and we have so far kept to that goal. Fr David keeps writing letters and Fr Seraphim keeps feeling way behind in writing personal letters. We would like to institute a

column in the newsletter of questions and answers, but that really depends on you doesn't it?

A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life

From "A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life", Hieroconfessor Alexander (Orlov) Of Omsk, who fell asleep in 1977 at the age of 99, translated by Protopresbyter Thomas Marretta. These gems of spiritual wisdom are sent in email messages from my good friend, Fr Demetrios Carellas. We will investigate getting copies of this book, to send to many of you. (Priest Seraphim)

3. Throughout the day, regardless of what you are doing or where you are, repeat short prayers. (especially, The Jesus Prayer: Lord Jesus Christ have mercy on me, and also: Most Holy Theotokos save us.) Prayers are the soul's wings. Prayer makes the soul God's throne. The power in a spiritual man comes entirely from prayer.

4.If you want God to hear your prayer, do not wag your tongue, but pray with your heart.

5.Sincerely greet everyone you meet in the morning

I could have known a Saint!

This story from Fr Moses Berry, published here with his personal permission, probably applies to each of us, don't you think? If, as the Scripture says, it is possible to entertain angels unawares, isn't it even more likely that we encounter holy people in our daily lives but and do not recognize them because of our judgments and our blindness?

A few years ago, I attended a nationwide church gathering in St. Louis, MO. It was held at the St. Louis Union Station convention center. After lunch, a friend and I were talking in the lobby, when an Afro-American man crossed our path. He was young, wore a black hoodie, black Levi jeans, and a pair of vintage-type Air Jordans. His pants were hung low on his hips, and he walked briskly. My friend, a fellow minister, said "how disrespectful!" stating that this young man must be up to no good. I asked him how he knew. He answered, "well, just look at him!"

"Let me tell you a story," I responded, and began. In my home town of Ash Grove, Missouri, there was a lady named Miss Olivia Murray. She was born in 1897 and died in 1991. She was the daughter of an enslaved woman, Fannie Murray, who was 12 years old at the end of the Civil War. Fannie's master set her free and on her own to roam the Ozark hills. Later, when word of this got to my great-grandparents, also freed slaves, they set aside a parcel of land for Fannie, where she could live out the rest of her days.

Miss Olivia was a tall, strong woman who walked around town with a bonnet on her head and a long dress and apron going nearly to the ground. She often carried a basket under her arms, and her little dog Wiggie ran in and out around her legs. She was quite an embarrassment to me, in the late 1950's, when we were trying to

shake off the fetters of subserviency. There she was, looking like Aunt Jemima. I don't mean the new, cute Aunt Jemima, but the old "Hattie Mcdaniel" version.

I once complained to my mother about the way Olivia Murray looked. My mother asked - do you know what she has in that basket? She has eggs from her chickens and canned goods from her garden, and she goes around giving them to people who are down on their luck. Mom went on to say, "She's saved many a family around here, including ours." I felt so ashamed. I could have known a saint.



We often accept or dismiss people on equally as flimsy evidence, and we could have known a saint. So be careful, brothers and sisters, how you treat your neighbors. Watch out, and don't make up a backstory for them based on a glance. You could miss someone precious, just like I missed knowing Miss Olivia.

A Word from Fr. Seraphim

Non-negotiables.

Do you have anything in your life that is "*non-negotiable*"? St. James teaches that a double-minded man is unstable in all of his ways. The true Christian is not double-minded, which means that there are things that he will not compromise on. What things will you compromise on and what things will you not compromise?

Of course, on a higher level, all of us should have the same list, shouldn't we? All of us should value prayer above everything, and all of us should love our enemy and should struggle for virtue. All of us should follow the greatest commandment and the second

one which is like it, and includes people that really irritate us, even in prison.

All of us should know what we are trying to live for (our purpose), and be resolutely unwilling to do anything that does not help this purpose. This is the same **exact** thing for all of us if we are doing it right. Do you know what that thing is? If you don't know what you're living for, then how are you going to live? Having non-negotiables helps us to be able to reach our goal, assuming of course we know it.

I'll tell you some of my *"non-negotiables"*. I can't say with a straight face that I value prayer above everything else in life, because I do other things sometimes instead of pray. I'm not talking about the things that you must be doing, but there are times when I could pray that I do not pray or when I am praying, I pray with less attention than I could pray. However, prayer for me is a *"non-negotiable"* as far as my weak flesh allows it to be. Because I cannot pray without ceasing and always be ready for prayer, I'd plan for prayer every day. I have two pillars for my daily plan for prayer. I always read the Psalter, and I always commemorate people. There might be other things that I do as well, such as read morning prayers or read Scripture, but absolutely positively the Psalter and commemorations are nonnegotiable.

I advise everyone to make a list of people to pray for. **We cannot say we love someone we do not pray for them.** My *"non-negotiable"* list includes *everyone* in my parish, everyone that I am aware of in our prison ministry (Fr. David and I have a consolidated list), and *"+Daniels list"*. The latter is a list of people that have died suddenly like my son +Daniel (+06/11/2017 ns) did, and also those that have lost someone suddenly, and those who pray for +Daniel.

Do you have any *"non-negotiable"* prayer list? If you don't, that I would ask you: "What are you doing?". Prayer is the most important thing you can do, and we must do something to start proving that we really believe this! Make a list of people that you should pray for. It's not that hard to know who should be on the list: Your family, your friends, your loved ones, those who minister to you, and especially, your enemies. That includes enemies that are dead. That includes people that hurt you or you hurt from long ago. If your heart resonates with any kind of anger or darkness or coldness when you think about a person, that person must be on your list! It is a *"non-negotiable"*.

What other *"non-negotiable"* things do you have in your life? I created *"+Daniels list"* because of one of my *"non-negotiables"*. That is, I must always react to something that is significant in my life, such as a great temptation, or great loss, or great problem. We don't take anything that is difficult passively! We attack it (since as the Scripture says, the kingdom of heaven is being taken by violence) with prayer and with activity. Find many times that you will make significant changes because of this principle. The loss of my son was a great loss, I had to do something. If grief just sits there, there is no growth, only a slow death. Therefore, I made a list and made a promise. To this day, I am still updating the list and adding names.

I live by another *"non-negotiable"* since I became an Orthodox Christian. This is obviously difficult for you to put in practice in prison, but you can find a way, if you really want to. From the time I became an Orthodox Christian, if I was capable of coming to the service, I did. It was *"non-negotiable"* for me that I could say: "I'm tired" or "I want to go to a concert" or "I want to study," or something else. If the church was open and I was able to come, I did. Of course, there are reasons why a person cannot come

to church, but they are rare in my experience. Now I am a priest, and of course if I don't serve the service, it doesn't happen. So, it's definitely a *"non-negotiable"* now but it always was.

What other *"non-negotiables"* might there be? I have made one regarding my youngest

grandsons. You see them in the picture, Owen, and Noah (L-R). I take care of Noah twice a week, with Noah with Owen once a week. When they were still in the womb, I was begging their parents to allow me to care for them at least once a week. It took a lot of "selling" to get it done, but it's clear now that they really love their Papa/Buh, and my care for them is a fixture in their life. Both my grandsons were born after my own son died. I had this incredible hunger within me to really pour myself into them, sort of an offering for Daniel. This is another example of an application of my *"non-negotiable"* that I must do something in reaction to things that really move me in life

There are moral *"non-negotiables"*. I have spoken many times in many letters about "penitentiary ethics". That's a type of conditional "honesty". This is really not honesty at all; it is a "doing what I need to do to get by" kind of honesty. This is despicable to God, because it is like being lukewarm. If you read in Revelations about lukewarm people, you don't want to be lukewarm. *It is always wrong to do wrong, and it is always right to do right.*

It should not be a *"non-negotiable"* to you that you must struggle against sins that you have weaknesses for. That means you should have a plan, and react to the sin you have committed it!

It should not be *"non-negotiable"* that you never dominate someone because you can.

Here's another thing that you should not be *"non-negotiable"* with. It's a hard one to put into practice. In prison, the sins of cynicism and bitterness and anger and despondency are very prevalent. They're also very prevalent in the world. That world is called the "Free World" but that's an oxymoron. Most people in the "Free World" are not free. You should make it a *"non-negotiable"* that when you are troubled by some pernicious thought or sin, you turn to God in prayer. Pray the "Jesus prayer" when you are tempted. Do not allow yourself the default thoughts that you see around you of cynicism, blaming others, and getting what I can, and doing what I can to survive. You're not trying to survive in prison! If you're trying to survive in prison you are definitely dying. You are trying to live in prison, that is, if you are Christian. You're trying to live with the Kingdom of Heaven within you, and in a spiritual way.



A word from Fr David

Salvation in an Age of Politics and Protests

If you pay any attention to the news, you may have heard that we are just a few socialist policy changes and radical cultural deconstructions away from near-utopia on earth. Some say that if we burn down our present system, we can build an earthly paradise of Peace and Justice, which man has been seeking for millennia. How does this claim compare to the life and teachings of our Savior?

Our Lord Jesus Christ didn't march on Jerusalem to win a holy war waged by His angels and servants, casting off the yoke of Caesar from the backs of the Jews; for this, in part, He was crucified by His own outraged and offended people. Christ never promised to free His children from the Romans, Ottomans, or Bolsheviks, by open combat or negotiated settlement; instead, He warned us to expect and endure persecution and injustice for His sake. His teaching was notably devoid of political slogans and policies. What victory, then, did He offer and achieve for us who bear our cross after Him? Deliverance from our true enemies and overlords: death, sin, and the devil. This may be the only "good news" you hear today, and yet it outweighs every headline, editorial, and political prescription that will vie for your attention.

What ails modern man? He demands freedom from adversity while living a slave to sin; he redecorates his spiritual prison cell with party banners, platitudes, and "memes" (social media sound bites), imagining that he has constructed a futuristic palace where justice, peace, and happiness will reign. Peering over the wall of his own sins, he condemns the sins of others - past and present - thinking he puts the world right by laying the blame for mankind's suffering at the feet of others, whether they be six feet under or six feet socially-distanced from him; only, let there be an impassible distance between him and the evil doers who are responsible for every ill. He will readily reproach the sins of others, and even confess his part of the collective guilt he ascribes to them, but he can barely notice, and can scarcely be troubled to ask forgiveness of, the suffering souls he alternately attacks and neglects around him. Such a man, evading responsibility for his own tragic condition, is a stranger to soul-saving repentance.

Suppose you were to visit a man in prison serving "life without parole" - condemned by society to live out his days as an outcast without chance of public rehabilitation. Will you advance him on the path to salvation by condemning his enemies as tyrants and sinners? Will a shaken fist of outrage bring spiritual peace to his soul? What truly comforts and uplifts the soul of the despairing and broken-hearted who seem beyond earthly consolation?

Strange as it might seem, such a person's redemption begins with his own heartfelt cry to the Lord, "I am the most sinful person!" It is cry that no other voice can utter on his behalf. From this sincere admission of all-encompassing guilt, the penitent opens the door to Christ's all-forgiving love. Here again, the good news of

the Gospel alone is sufficient to raise the dead and set the captive free:

And whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted. (Matt. 23:12)

As a light in our present darkness, consider a saintly example of spiritual joy and everlasting freedom which shone forth in the tomb of Communist 'gulag' (hard labor and torture prisons). Righteous Valeriu Gafencu, "Saint of Romanian Prisons", pray to God for us!

[Here follows an excerpt from an article on the life of Valeriu Gafencu, published by OrthoChristian.com]:

Spiritual books helped Valeriu see things more deeply and turn more toward his inner self. In the solitude of his cell he prayed very much, seeking to understand the meaning of suffering. After a time of tormenting unrest and struggle, he experienced through the grace of God a state of enlightenment in which he saw his soul full of sins.

"After a time of much uneasiness, after experiencing a great deal of pain, when the cup of suffering had filled up, there came a holy day, in June 1943, when I fell to the ground, on my knees, my head bent, my heart shattered, in a burst of tears. I prayed to God that He grant me light. At that point I had lost all faith in people. I realized perfectly well that I was in truth, but then why was I suffering? Within my zealous soul only love had remained. No one understood me.

"During this long period of weeping I began to do prostrations. And suddenly — O Lord! How great art thou, Lord! — I saw my soul full of sins, I found within myself the root of all the sins of mankind. Alas, so many sins, and the eyes of my soul, hardened by pride, had not seen them. How great is God!

"Seeing all my sins, I felt the need to shout them forth and cast them away from me. And a deep peace, a deep wave of light and love poured into my heart. As soon as the door opened, I left my cell and went to those whom I knew to love me and to those who hated me and to those who had most wronged me and I confessed to them openly, 'I am the most sinful man. I do not deserve the trust of even the last among men. I am blessed!'

"Everyone was astounded. Some looked at me with disdain, others with indifference. Some looked at me with a love that they themselves could not have explained. A single person said to me, 'You deserve to be kissed.' But I fled quickly back to my cell,



threw my head into my pillow and continued my weeping, thanking and glorifying God."

This moment of enlightenment was a true rebirth for Valeriu. The most immediate benefit of the awareness of sins is the understanding of the meaning of suffering.

Gleanings from the Fathers: Humility

To be saved, we must humble ourselves, for the proud man even were he to be set down in paradise would not find peace there but would be discontent, and say, 'Why am I not up in the front rank?' But the humble soul is filled with love and does not seek to be in the foreground. The humble soul wishes good to all men, and in all things is content. - Saint Silouan of Mount Athos (+1938), from "St. Silouan the Athonite" by Archimandrite Sophrony

Humble-mindedness will bring all the virtues. St. Anthimos of Chios +1960

Humility is, not only to humble your own self, but also to forbear the humiliations which others impose on you. Archimandrite Joel Giannakopoulos +1966

Prayer is grace. God gives it when there exists zeal and humility... Let Christ not be missing from your heart. Elder Amphilochios of Patmos +1970

... reading and spiritual knowledge are good, but only when they lead to greater humility... St. Peter of Damaskos (Book 1: A Treasury of Divine Knowledge, The Philokalia Vol. 3 pg. 169)

...true humility does not say humble words, nor does it assume humble looks, it does not force oneself either to think humbly of oneself, or to abuse oneself in self-belittlement. Although all such things are the beginning, the manifestations and the various aspects of humility, humility itself is grace, given from above. There are two kinds of humility, as the holy fathers teach: to deem oneself the lowest of all beings and to ascribe to God all one's good actions. The first is the beginning, the second the end. St. Gregory of Sinai (Texts on Commandments and Dogmas no. 115)

A brother from Abba Poemen's neighborhood left to go to another country one day. There he met an anchorite. The latter was very charitable and many came to see him. The brother told him about Abba Poemen. When he heard of his virtue, the anchorite wanted to see him. Sometime afterwards when the brother had returned to Egypt the anchorite went there to see the brother who had formerly paid him a visit. He had told him where he lived.

"Suffering, no matter how difficult it may be, has no other meaning than the cleansing of souls thirsting for salvation.

When he saw him, the brother was astonished and very pleased. The anchorite said to him, "Please, will you be so kind as to take me to Abba Poemen?" So he brought him to the old man and presented him, saying, "This is a great man, full of charity, who is held in high estimation in his district. I have spoken to him about you, and he has come because he wants to see you." So, Abba Poemen received him with joy. They greeted one another and sat down.

The visitor began to speak of the Scriptures, of spiritual and of heavenly things. But Abba Poemen turned his face away and answered nothing. Seeing that he did not speak to him, the other went away deeply grieved and said to the brother who had brought him, "I have made this long journey in vain. For I have come to see the old man, and he does not wish to speak to me."

Then the brother went inside to Abba Poemen and said to him, "Abba, this great man who has so great a reputation in his own country has come here because of you. Why did you not speak to him?" The old man said, "He is great and speaks of heavenly things and I am lowly and speak of earthly things. If he had spoken of the passions of the soul, I should have replied, but he speaks to me of spiritual things and I know nothing about that."

Then the brother came outside and said to the visitor, "The old man does not readily speak of the Scriptures, but if anyone consults him about the passions of the soul, he replies." Filled with compunction, the visitor returned to the old man and said to him, "What should I do, Abba, for the passions of the soul master me?"

The old man turned towards him and replied joyfully, "This time, you come as you should. Now open your mouth concerning this and I will fill it with good things." Greatly edified, the other said to him, "Truly, this is the right way!"

He returned to his own country giving thanks to God that he had been counted worthy to meet so great a saint. "The Desert Christian," by Benedicta Ward, (New York: MacMillan, 1975), p. 167

¹ 1 Peter 1:8-12 Whom having not seen, ye love; in whom, though now ye see *him* not, yet believing, ye rejoice with joy unspeakable and full of glory: (9) Receiving the end of your faith, *even* the salvation of *your* souls. (10) Of which salvation the prophets have enquired and searched diligently, who prophesied of the *grace that should come* unto you: (11) Searching what, or what manner of time the Spirit of Christ which was in them did signify, when it testified beforehand the sufferings of Christ, and the glory that should follow. (12) Unto whom it was revealed, that not unto themselves, but unto us they did minister the things, which are now reported unto you by them that have preached the gospel unto you with the Holy Ghost sent down from heaven; which things the angels desire to look into.